

Fistfuls of Power

Agent 001 scouts the market for a handheld device that fits his pocket

It was one of those mornings where you get up feeling something essential is missing. I checked to see if all my appendages were in place, they were. My trademark goatee then? No, that felt right too. Then suddenly I hit upon it, I didn't have a handheld! Oh the shame of it all, me being a techno-geek and all that. Of course, I did need it for the practicality of being connected to my data and information wherever I went, but that's secondary. A handheld I want and a handheld I shall get. First stop, to the bank. Turns out I have just enough, so off I go.

Before I indulge myself, I chalk out the list of functions I intend to use my new toy for. Hmm, I need it for reading my e-books and Web pages, and it must have good organisation capabilities to make sense of my chaos. A little ability to synchronise with other external applications wouldn't hurt either—all this at the lowest possible price, of course.

The most affordable device in the market right now is the Palm m100 priced at Rs 6,000. Though its specifications are showing signs of age—2 MB of memory and a basic monochrome screen doesn't really allow much, but is suited to text-based applications. Placed a notch higher is the Palm m105 with 8 MB of memory, costing Rs 8,500. But there's a new kid on the block, the funky Palm Zire made for first time users. However, none of the dealers I spoke to in Andheri, Mumbai, would give away its price.

Next up, I spotted the Palm m125 monochrome with expansion slots for MMC and Secure Digital cards. This one had 8 MB of memory and came with the mandatory set of organisation software and synchronisation via infrared and USB connectivity. The Palm m130 is also sim-

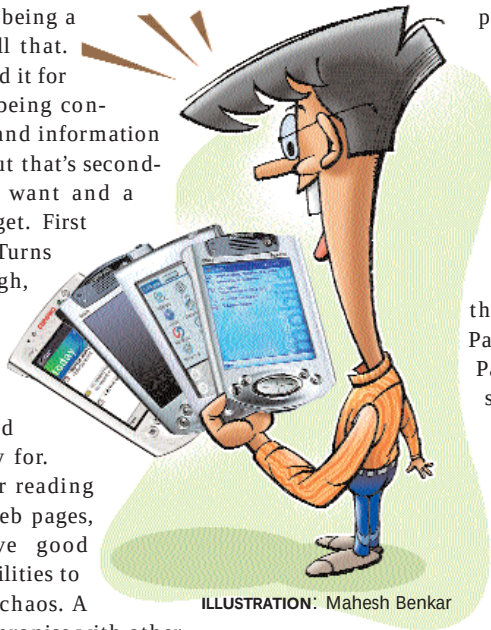
ilar but it has a slightly bigger colour screen. The Palm m125 uses AAA batteries, while the Palm m130 uses rechargeable Lithium Ion batteries and has very good battery life. The m125 costs around Rs 11,000, while the m130 is priced at

around Rs 13,500. The prices are about Rs 500 to Rs 1,000 more in the white market and you get the advantage of a solid warranty and a boxed package.

Still higher are the popular 500-series Palm devices. The Palm m500 has a sharp monochrome screen with 8 MB of memory, a faster processor than the m1xx series and is one of the lightest devices available. The colour device in this range was the Palm m515,

which has 16 MB of memory and uses a rechargeable Lithium Ion battery with Flash ROM upgrade capabilities. The m500 is priced at around Rs 18,000 while the colour m515 comes in at around Rs 23,000. On the higher end, the new Palm Tungsten T device has an ARM-based processor and a crisp colour display. It runs the latest Palm OS 5 software and is packed to the gills with features such as 16 MB of memory, Bluetooth, voice memo, headset jack and even cellular phone capabilities. All these features obviously mean a high price, but here too, none of the dealers had any information.

I even checked out the Pocket PC arena, but most the dealers stocked only the Compaq iPAQ series of handhelds, with the iPAQ 3800 being the most popular choice. It comes with 64 MB of memory and runs Microsoft Pocket PC 2002. With full multimedia capabilities



■ **Memory:** Depending upon the types of applications you plan to use, a handheld's integrated memory could run out faster than you would imagine. You will need at least 4 MB of memory for text-based applications and 16 MB for storing media files.

■ **Compatibility:** Your handheld should support your applications and be able to exchange information with your desktop PC and other handheld devices.

■ **Expandability and upgradability:** Choose handhelds that allow the OS to be upgraded. Look out for ones that allow the firmware to be upgraded through Flash programs.

■ **Screen size and resolution:** Monochrome screens are suited to most applications; colour screens are for those who intend to work with graphics and video files. Look for a colour screen with good resolution, clarity and brightness, and one that is clearly legible in the dark as well as in bright light.

■ **Battery life:** Rechargeable Lithium Ion batteries are preferable for longer on-road life. Even if it uses conventional alkaline batteries, make sure it has a run time of at least 10 hours.

■ **Integrated features:** Opt for devices with additional features such as a cellular phone or camera only if you are going to actually use them. These frills add significantly to the cost.

(yes, it can play back MP3s as well as movie clips), a full colour screen and plenty of application and organisation software, it does full justice to its price tag of Rs 33,000. Similar in capabilities are Pocket PCs from other brands such as Toshiba, Casio, HP, etc. However, none of them came lower than Rs 25,000. Oh well...

Acknowledging that the world of Pocket PCs held nothing for me, I settled for the Palm m125. It suited my needs quite well and left me with enough money to get back home! 🏠